



Terracotta Army

The most spectacular archaeological find of modern times, opening a unique window on China's past

Discovered by local farmers near Mount Li in China's Shaanxi province in 1974, the massed life-size figures known as the Terracotta Army are more than 2,000 years old. They form part of the mausoleum of Qin Shi Huang (259–210 BCE), who styled himself the “First Emperor” of China. Obsessed with death from an early age, Qin Shi Huang began creating the burial complex in 246 BCE, when he was only 13 years old and ruler of Qin, one of the seven major states into which China was then divided. From 221 BCE, with all of China united under his iron rule, he was able to mobilize massive resources for the mausoleum project.

Buried ranks

The Terracotta Army—consisting of at least 7,000 soldiers; 130 horse-drawn chariots; and 150 cavalry horses—guarded one side of the extensive imperial burial site. Most of the figures represent peasant foot soldiers arrayed in orderly ranks. Crossbowmen are shown kneeling and horsemen astride their mounts. As befits their status, the officer figures are taller and wear more elaborate armor. The real iron or bronze weapons they carried in their terracotta hands have been looted or disintegrated over time.

MASS PRODUCTION

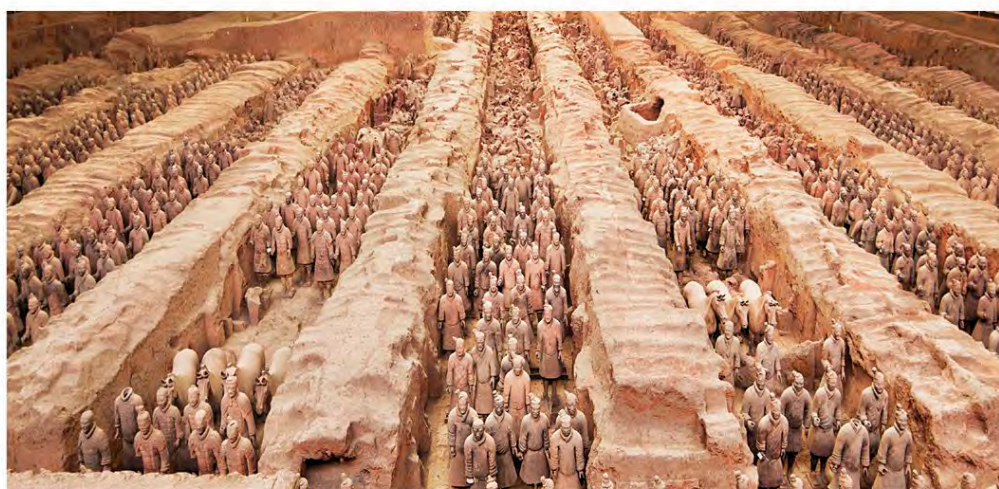
The terracotta figures were created in workshops using mass-production techniques. The different parts were created in standard molds, fired separately, and then assembled. There were 10 basic molds for heads, with facial features added by hand to give them individuality.

figures held real iron or bronze weapons

painted and lacquered surface has degraded over time



Around **700,000 workers** were employed to help build the **emperor's mausoleum**



◁ BATTLE FORMATION

Three vaults were found, with figures all facing east, toward the enemies of the Qin. Two vaults were on the flanks and the third was the command post at the rear.

▷ ETERNAL GUARD

The figures of the soldiers are 5 ft 10 in (1.8 m) tall on average. Their headgear was an indication of their status and rank.

